

# REEL PARADISE

A documentary film by Steve James

A View Askew Production

Executive Producers

**Kevin Smith**

**John Pierson**

**Janet Pierson**

Producers

**Steve James**

**Scott Mosier**

Directed by

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## ***Reel Paradise***

### **Synopsis**

***Reel Paradise*** tells the story of John Pierson's family at the end of a year-long adventure on a remote island in Fiji where they ran the 180 Meridian Cinema, showing free movies to the locals.

John Pierson is a noted indie film maven, author of the widely celebrated book, *Spike, Mike, Slackers & Dykes*, who together with his wife Janet created the IFC cable show *Split Screen*. On one story for the show, John and family went to Fiji in search of the "world's most remote movie theater."

John fell in love with the 180 Meridian Cinema when he saw the wild enthusiasm of the audience to a showing of the Three Stooges' *Some More of Samoa* – a short they had been showing at the theater since it opened in 1954. "I'd never remotely heard anything like that," John says in *Reel Paradise*. "This is somehow what I missed back when movies meant everything to people."

John decided he wanted to move with his family to Fiji and observe what movies meant to this country on the other side of the world. He also saw this adventure as an opportunity to plunge his two kids, Georgia (16) and Wyatt (13), into a culture and lifestyle far different from that of their home outside New York City.

Filmed during the last month of the family's yearlong stay in Fiji, *Reel Paradise* aims to reveal something of what the whole year has been like for the Piersons. The rural island of Taveuni is not one of Fiji's prime tourist destinations. Like most of the south Pacific islands, its people struggle to eke out a subsistence living as farmers, fisherman, and merchants. To the local Fijians, the Piersons are thought to be millionaires, because they are able to live in a large colonial home and show movies for free. (The home is indeed impressive by Fijian standards, though barely acceptable by middle-class western standards.)

Georgia and Wyatt are enrolled in the local Catholic high school, where they are the only white students. They gamely throw themselves into this very different school environment where some view them as curiosities, and others as suspicious outsiders. The kids form friendships with some classmates, many of whom live in the nearby village of Natokalau but come to treat the Pierson house as a second home. Janet follows their lead, befriending some of the families in the village.

John's village, says Janet, is the movie theater. John carries on the theater's tradition of showing a wide range of American, British and Hindi films. (The Fijian population is split between native Fijian islanders and Indo-Fijians whose ancestors immigrated here as indentured servants starting in the 1880s.) The profound difference now is John's ability to show the movies for free due to contributions from indie filmmakers he had helped in the past. For many in Taveuni, going to movies had been impossibly expensive before the Piersons

arrived. Now, the 180 Meridian Cinema becomes the focal point of entertainment on the island with frequent packed houses. John is able to secure many of the most current popular and blockbuster releases from America and abroad, everything from *Rabbit Proof Fence* and *Bend it Like Beckham*, to *The Scorpion King* and *The Hot Chick*. For their last month in Fiji, John programs a special ten-day movie marathon featuring films like *Matrix Reloaded*, *Bringing Down the House*, *Apocalypse Now Redux*, and *Jackass*.

Because the Piersons are neither tourists nor permanent residents of Taveuni, their year here proves to be a complicated experience. They form strong friendships with locals like their cook Sia, and come to understand how third world islanders cope with day-to-day life. But they also experience culture clash and learn firsthand the realities of being “haves” in a culture of “have-nots.” Early in the film their home is robbed while they are out showing a movie. It’s the second such serious robbery since they’ve been in Fiji, and raises anew questions about whom they can trust or not trust. Their paranoia extends to their landlord Andrew, an Australian ex-patriot who lives on the property and has been a yearlong thorn in the side of the Pierson family. When Andrew insensitively presents the Pierson’s with a fuel bill the night of the second robbery, it strikes another blow against the notion that living here can be some kind of paradise.

As *Reel Paradise* unfolds, we see the differing ways in which each of the Piersons deals with living in this very different culture. Showing movies for free makes John instantly famous as “Uncle John” to the locals – especially those that could never afford to go to the movies otherwise. Yet, the free movies also bring John into direct conflict with some of the local Catholic priests, a battle he humorously characterizes as being for the “souls of the people of Taveuni.” Wyatt becomes a star pupil at school, praised repeatedly by teachers and administrators. Because the curriculum is not challenging for her, Georgia struggles with some of her teachers while forming a deep friendship with a local classmate named Miriama. School may be a bust for her, but she clearly loves Fijian life.

The Piersons grant the filmmakers unusually intimate access to the family’s home life. The result is a frank portrait of a very American family abroad. We see the struggles between Georgia and her parents around typical issues for American 16 year-olds, now exacerbated by living in a culture in which children are never expected to talk back to parents. Yet, Georgia’s friend Miriama prefers to stay with the Piersons instead of her own family where the father has been violent towards her and her mother. We also see that though Wyatt may be the quiet obedient student at school, he can be a tough and ruthlessly funny critic of his father and mother at home. Through it all, we see Janet playing the role of peacekeeper, the voice of reason during a particularly tumultuous last month abroad.

By the end of the film, we see how the Piersons have both been changed and unchanged by their experience. As unusually candid subjects, the family does not sugarcoat their feelings towards each other or their experience in Fiji. But

underneath it all, there is no mistaking their affection for both. The last movie in the ten-day marathon (and last scene in the film) captures the essence of what John went searching for in Fiji. He shows Buster Keaton's classic, *Steamboat Bill Jr.*, in part because he thought its climatic hurricane sequence would connect with the Fijians who had suffered through a devastating hurricane months earlier. The audience's howls of laughter betray the sweet release that great comedy can bring to hard lives. John says, "You almost feel like it's a cure for all that ails you. It was like nothing else matters anymore. All will be right with the world."

## Cast List

Appearing as themselves in the film:

**John Pierson**

**Janet Pierson**

**Georgia Pierson**

**Wyatt Pierson**

**Miriama Bibi** – Georgia's close friend

**Andrew Coghill** – the landlord

**Tawake Evans** – Wyatt's best friend

**Petero Gopal** – Sia's husband, the cane knife incident

**Teresia (Sia) Gopal** – family cook & friend

**Vijen Nair** – manager of Damodar Brothers, Fijian distributor/exhibitor

**Keni Madden** – friend & long-time (John Wayne) 180MC attendee

**Detective Narayan** – CSI Fiji

**Waisako Rokotuitai** – "protects" John at cinema ("Him and the wife are different")

**Elia Bibi** – projectionist (X2 trailer upside down & backwards)

**Namaj & Domingo** – AWOL projectionists, Namaj in the green truck

**Marica Tabalala** – Holy Cross principal (the western media)

**Vilimone Ragiawa** – Primary school headmaster (European tricks)

**Lavinia Taylor** – Georgia's friend, searching for her

**Vilisita Evans** – Tawake's mother

**Father Ben McKenna** – Marist priest/Tutu Mission ("John was proud of what he wrote")

**Brother Simon O'Connor** – Marist priest/Tutu Mission

**Subhash Chandra** – eldest Dayaram son ("Of course you can come. You'll have to pay.")

**Dhansukh Lal** – middle Dayaram son who ran the 180MC, now in NZ

**Ambaran Dayaram** – the patriarch who built the 180MC

## **180 MERIDIAN CINEMA/THE YEAR IN PICTURES**

### **All Movies Shown For Free (alphabetical)**

|                                         |                                    |
|-----------------------------------------|------------------------------------|
| 28 Days Later                           | Mohabbatein (India)                |
| 8 Mile                                  | Monsters Inc                       |
| Accidental Spy, The (w/ Jackie Chan)    | My Big Fat Greek Wedding (DNP)     |
| Ali                                     | National Security                  |
| Apocalypse Now Redux                    | Nurse Is Worse (Three Stooges)     |
| Austin Powers in Goldmember             | Oceans 11                          |
| Baby Boy                                | Panic Room                         |
| Bad Company                             | Rabbit-Proof Fence                 |
| Bend It Like Beckham                    | Rock Star                          |
| Blackhawk Down                          | Scorpion King, The                 |
| Bourne Identity, The                    | Shanghai Knights                   |
| Bringing Down The House                 | Signs                              |
| Catch Me If You Can                     | Some More of Samoa (Three Stooges) |
| Chicago                                 | Sorority Boys                      |
| Core, The                               | Spider-Man                         |
| Cradle 2 The Grave                      | Spy Kids                           |
| Crossroads                              | Steamboat Bill Jr.                 |
| Darkness Falls                          | Stuart Little 2                    |
| Devdas (India)                          | The One (w/ Jet Li)                |
| Die Another Day                         | Training Day                       |
| Don't Say A Word                        | Tuxedo, The                        |
| Drunken Master II                       | Two Weeks Notice                   |
| E.T.                                    | Undercover Brother                 |
| Enough                                  | X-2                                |
| Fast and the Furious, The               | XXX                                |
| Gangs of New York                       |                                    |
| Harry Potter and the Chamber of Secrets |                                    |
| Harry Potter and the Sorcerer's Stone   |                                    |
| Hot Chick, The                          |                                    |
| Humraaz (India)                         |                                    |
| Ice Age                                 |                                    |
| Insomnia                                |                                    |
| Jackass                                 |                                    |
| Johnny English                          |                                    |
| Juwanna Mann                            |                                    |
| Kaante (India)                          |                                    |
| Kabhi Khushi Kabhie Gham (India)        |                                    |
| Lagaan (India)                          |                                    |
| Like Mike                               |                                    |
| Lord of the Rings: The Fellowship       |                                    |
| Lord of the Rings: The Two Towers       |                                    |
| Maid In Manhattan                       |                                    |
| Matrix Reloaded, The                    |                                    |
| Matrix, The                             |                                    |
| Men In Black II                         |                                    |





## Director's Statement

By Steve James

I'll never forget when John first called me about his adventure in Fiji after he'd returned from shooting that *Split Screen* episode at the 180 Meridian Cinema. He seemed almost as animated then as (I would later learn) he had been the night of the Three Stooges showing that spurred his epiphany. John told me of his plans to return for an extended period of time. He said he wanted to show the movies for free and that his family was going along. As he talked, each revelation seemed more fantastic than the previous one.

Then John hit me up for a donation to the cause. He did so gently, because he knew I was living (mostly) on a documentary filmmaker's income. He said he was asking filmmakers he had known or been involved with over the years. Some had leaped in with support (Kevin Smith, *South Park*'s Matt Stone, the Haxan Films/Blair Witch team), some had been bewildered (Michael Moore's six word email response had been, "Ugh, tell me this isn't happening.") and others had pleaded poverty. I pleaded poverty. I wished I could have helped. I'd met John while completing *Hoop Dreams* in 1993. He didn't represent the film but he became an advisor who really beat the drum for it when we went to Sundance.

After the phone call, the next time I heard from John was at Sundance 2003 when my film *Stevie* was at the festival. I was checking my emails and got one from him wishing me luck with the film. He then asked if I had any interest in directing a documentary on their experiences in Fiji. Like many others, I had sporadically followed the family's exploits in Fiji via their website, so I knew the broad strokes of the story. John told me in the email that Kevin Smith and partner Scott Mosier would be the executive producers and they'd secured the money to fund the film. I said to myself, "Let's see, a funded film where I get to go to Fiji and document a unique family's experience abroad showing free movies on a remote island?" It took me about three seconds to say yes.

Despite my ready enthusiasm, I had no interest in doing a vanity piece. Thank-fully, John and Janet made it clear from the start that this would be my film, and they expected it to be as candid and honest as I could make it. That's not an easy thing to commit to for any subject of a documentary, let alone ones who are as media-savvy and self-aware as the Piersons.

But that is exactly what happened. Certainly one of the defining characteristics of *Reel/Paradise* is the honest - sometimes joyous sometimes painful - depiction of their lives in Fiji. The film is neither a Pollyanna portrait of the Piersons nor, for that matter, of the Fijians. The film shows that life is hard there in differing ways for both the family and locals.

Though we filmed for only the last month, it was a full one. In addition to the ten-movie marathon, there's the delinquent projectionist, the robbery, dengue fever, and those family conflicts. The film also presented me with an opportunity to get to know some of



the Fijian people in the Piersons' lives. Then there were the audiences at the movies. Nowhere in the world have I seen such visceral and passionate responses to a movie. In *Reel Paradise*, we really tried to capture the experience inside that theater. Being there, I realized why John had been so affected by his first visit to the 180 Meridian Theater, and why he wanted so badly to come back.

Yet despite the richness of that month of shooting, it's true that no film can fully capture a subject's experience. My *modus operandi* on my previous films (including the recent miniseries on immigrants in America, *The New Americans*) is to shoot for years at a time. Indeed, for this film, I could have easily imagined myself shooting periodically over the entire year of their stay. But that wasn't possible because funding came later. And in fact, it wasn't desirable either for the Piersons. They needed to spend the bulk of their time in Fiji just living their lives, without the camera.

I like to think of my films as acts of discovery. I may start with a solid idea or expectation of where the story is headed. But every time, the story ends up taking me in a different direction. That's the powerful allure of documentary filmmaking: to let the subjects and the story dictate the direction of the film, not the other way around.

For example, going in I had greater expectations that the film would explore the meaning of free movies on the locals. But what I found was that impact and meaning are hard things to quantify or even articulate in a culture where English is a second language and many of those in attendance are either not formally educated or young students. (Which only made me turn the question back on America. Despite our media inundated culture, greater wealth and education, we still have no real idea how to quantify the impact of movies here at home. It remains a source of huge debate.)

What did emerge for me was a story about a family abroad and the how each member of that family coped with and was changed (or not changed) by their Fijian experience. The Pierson family became a kind of metaphor for the differing ways America is in the world. John is a larger than life figure: a man on a mission in the quintessential American sense. His mission is movies, sometimes in opposition to that of the church there. Janet is in many ways John's mirror opposite. If John is the American proselytizer, Janet is the American diplomat. Georgia may struggle with authority at home and school, yet she displayed absolute ease with Fijian culture and kids of all ages. And despite Wyatt's great ability to adapt to the local culture, he was still very much his father's son.

*Reel Paradise* was an extremely provocative, at times funny, and other times enlightening experience. It is my hope that we have made such a film.

## **Fiji Facts**

Fiji consists of 323 islands in the Pacific Ocean just over the International Dateline slightly below the equator in the Southern Hemisphere. So it's already tomorrow, and it's summer.

Because it's tropical, you wouldn't know it was winter, spring, summer, or fall. It's permanently hot and wet. Days and nights are always about 12 hours long.

It's been an independent republic since 1970 with a parliamentary government. It was a British colony before then.

Early colonial-era missionaries pacified the warrior Fijians who had once practiced cannibalism. In fact Fiji was once called the Cannibal Isles.

The British colonialists brought in Indian labor for the sugar plantations, so Fiji has a large minority Indo-Fijian population with its own culture. They cannot own tribal land.

English is a second (or even third, after Hindi) language. But it is still indisputably the language in school. And literacy rates, on paper at least, are surprisingly high.

The most recent coup was in May 2000 not long after the Piersons' initial Split Screen visit. That fourth coup, by nativist Fijians, overturned a legitimately elected Indian prime minister.

Taveuni is the third largest island in Fiji. But it's still only 25 miles long and 8 miles wide – a cigar shape. A volcanic ridge down the middle divides the wild, unoccupied ocean side from the sheltered part where almost all the villages (and the 180 Meridian Cinema) are located.

Taveuni's population is reportedly about 10,000 in a string of villages along the one mostly dirt road. Perhaps 2,000-3,000 residents are within 5km walking distance of the cinema. The buses don't run after dark. There are only 409 registered vehicles.

Taveuni is the Garden Island, rural even by Fijian standards. The cash crops are dalo (taro), copra (coconuts) and kava (a narcotic root). There is no public electricity. Merchants, ex-pats and a few others have generators.

Village social life centers around the grog bowl. Grog is the brownish fluid that results when you pound the kava root into a powder then strain water through it. (Other islands chew it and spit it out first.) Men and women, but mainly men, drink it communally in a semi-ritualistic manner for many hours each night. It's numbing.

Taveuni has two chiefs, the Tui Cakau (pronounced Tooey The Cow) and the Tui Vuna. They control the mataqalis which collectively own or lease the land. In all of Fiji, the Fijians retain ownership of 83% of the land.

Although the Methodists wielded the greatest missionary influence across Fiji, the Catholics have had quite a long-time, historic stronghold on Taveuni – both regular Catholics and the more doctrinaire (anti-free movie) Marist Brothers. Taveuni also has Mormons, Jehovah's Witnesses and Seventh Day Adventists.

Fiji has one television station, Fiji 1. Each Taveuni village has one television. Everyone gathers on Friday evening for the top-rated show, Walker: Texas Ranger.

Rupert Murdoch owns the major newspaper, the Fiji Times. It's a good-hearted, unifying, liberal publication. It has no film critic.

The Damodar Brothers (some call them the Fijian Weinsteins) are the only English-language film distributors. They import titles from all the Hollywood studios and the British Commonwealth. They are based in the capital city of Suva on the big island Viti Levu where they also operate the fabulous Village 6 multiplex.

Many films at the Village 6 open day & date with the U.S. Because of the dateline, this can actually mean a day ahead of the U.S. The reason is that piracy in Fiji is rampant and almost every title is bootlegged with impunity within a short time. So the studios make hay during the short window.

The 180 Meridian Cinema was built by Ambaran Dayaram and opened in 1954 with Burt Lancaster's His Majesty O'Keefe, filmed in Fiji. Ambaran's middle son Dhansukh Lal ran the theater for 30 years before emigrating to New Zealand in 2002.

Movies used to cost \$2 Fijian which used to be about \$1 U.S. Attendance had sagged due to video (available to the wealthy Indians) and a depressed local agricultural economy.

In the 60's, aside from the Hindi films, John Wayne, Elvis Presley and The Sound of Music ruled. In recent times, old school action idols like Van Damme, Seagal, Stallone & Norris are still gods.

The island that Mel Gibson recently bought is in the Lau Group east of Taveuni on the way to Tonga. Malcolm Forbes' ashes are scattered on his beloved private island Laucala just north of Taveuni. Many Hollywood and Australian superstars like to luxuriate at the very exclusive Wakaya Club 100 miles southwest of Taveuni.

## Principals' Bios

**STEVE JAMES (director, producer, editor)** is best known as the award-winning director, producer, and co-editor of *Hoop Dreams*, which swept every major documentary award of 1994, among them, the Robert F. Kennedy Journalism Award and the Peabody Award. James recently served as an executive producer, story director, and series editor on *The New Americans*, a seven-hour miniseries on the lives of contemporary immigrants that aired to critical acclaim on PBS in 2004. The series won two Golden Hugos at the Chicago International Television Festival and recently won the 2004 Independent Documentary Association Award for Best Limited Series for Television.

In 2002, James produced, directed and edited *Stevie*, which won the coveted grand jury prizes at the International Documentary Film Festival Amsterdam and the Philadelphia Film Festival, and won major prizes at the 2003 Sundance Film Festival and Yamagata International Documentary Film Festival. The acclaimed film was released theatrically and landed on more than a dozen "Ten Best Films of 2003" lists.

**SCOTT MOSIER (producer)** is the house producer of Kevin Smith's New Jersey-based production company, View Askew Productions (home to their New Jersey series: *Clerks*, *Jay and Silent Bob Strike Back* and *Jersey Girl*). Scott has edited all but one of this series of films (MALLRATS).

Scott Mosier has also executive produced four micro-budget features under the View Askew banner: *Vulgar*, a Lions Gate release for spring 2002, *A Better Place*, *Drawing Flies*, and *Big Helium Dog*. He has also produced a series of MTV commercial spots starring Jay and Silent Bob (re-occurring characters in Smith's movies). Mosier also co-executive produced, with Smith, the Academy Award winning film *Good Will Hunting*. With Smith, Mosier also executive produced with Miramax and Disney animation, *The Clerks Animated Television Show* for ABC prime-time television. Mosier and Smith continue to help independent filmmakers on the path to their own feature film careers.

**KEVIN SMITH (executive producer)** In the few years since his entry into the indie film community, Kevin Smith has seen it all - from the surprise critical and commercial success he received for his debut film *Clerks*, to the disappointing critical and commercial drubbing he took on his second outing *Mallrats*. He caught a break on his third film, the critically hailed *Chasing Amy*, and managed not to get killed by the religious zealots over his fourth film, the comedic spiritual meditation *Dogma*. With the aptly titled *Jay and Silent Bob Strike Back*, Smith wrapped up the five-film "Jersey Trilogy" and headed for more grown up territory with *Jersey Girl*.

As for the hood ornaments he's collected, there's plenty of tin to go around: the Filmmaker's Trophy at Sundance for *Clerks*; the Prix de la Jeunesse and the International Critic's Week Award at the Cannes Film Festival, also for *Clerks*: The

Independent Spirit Award for Best Screenplay for *Chasing Amy*, and a Humanitas Award for *Good Will Hunting*. The Video Software Dealer's Association named him Visionary of the Year for his longtime commitment to the DVD format and sales success in the field. Smith also received the Defender of Democracy Award from Norman Lear's People for the American Way organization for his production of *Dogma*. For his writing in the comics field, Smith has received a Harvey Award, a Wizard Fan Award, an Eagle Award, and had *Green Arrow: Quiver* named as one of 2003's Best Books for Young Adults by the American Library Association's Young Adult Library Service. In the fall of 2002, the town of Paulsboro in NJ named a street after him: Kevin Smith Way.

**JOHN PIERSON (executive producer, subject)** graduated from NYU Film School in January 1977. Twenty-five years later, he left America behind to show free movies at the world's most remote theater, Fiji's 180 Meridian Cinema. In between, he played many pivotal roles in bringing the work of first-time filmmakers like Spike Lee, Michael Moore, Kevin Smith and Richard Linklater to the screen, a portfolio that *Premiere* called "a virtual hit parade of the independent movement." These tales are chronicled in John's book *Spike, Mike, Slackers & Dykes: A Guided Tour Across a Decade of American Independent Cinema*, revised and reissued in 2004 as *Spike Mike Reloaded*. Peter Biskind calls it "the bible for independents."

He was also creator and host of *Split Screen*, a half-hour magazine-format television show on IFC. Over its four year run, *Split Screen* spawned features ranging from *The Blair Witch Project* to *How's Your News?* Often in partnership with his wife and Rainy Pictures co-president Janet Pierson, John has directed film festivals, staged annual film workshops, and formed a completion funding company. He also executive produced *Chasing Amy* and once acted opposite Chris Noth.

The Piersons now live in Austin, TX where John teaches in the UT film department and is preparing a *Split Screen* box set with Aspyr Media.

**JANET PIERSON (executive producer, subject)**, co-president of Rainy Pictures, has partnered with her husband John Pierson professionally since 1986. In 2002-2003, they showed free movies at the world's most remote cinema in Taveuni, Fiji. She was co-creator, executive producer and occasional segment director of their magazine-format cable television series, *Split Screen*. Earlier projects include staging the Cold Spring Film Workshop and serving as producer reps and/or investors in over two dozen original American independent features like *She's Gotta Have It*, *Roger & Me*, *Slacker*, and *Clerks*. From 1981 to 1986 she was assistant director of NYC's Film Forum. In 1977-1979 she ran Canyon Cinema Cooperative in S.F. She attended Hampshire College, graduating with a BFA from the San Francisco Art Institute in 1977. Having recently relocated to Austin with her family, Janet is now on the board of the Austin Film Society.

**P.H. O'BRIEN (co-producer, director of photography)** has been a writer, producer, director and cinematographer for the past ten years. P.H. worked as a producer/director for John Pierson's acclaimed TV show, *Split Screen*, which aired on the Independent Film Channel (IFC) for four years. He wore several hats as a part of *How's Your News?* documentary that aired on Cinemax and PBS after debuting at the 2001 Toronto Film Festival. A second *How's Your News?* feature, focusing on the American political process is currently in post-production. He has also produced and shot shows for American Movie Classics, the BBC, History Channel and Lifetime. P.H. has written and is currently in pre-production on a narrative feature called *Route 1* to be directed by him in 2005. He lives in North Reading, Massachusetts where he enjoys watching movies, moving and restoring pre-1900 buildings, eating Japanese food and Oreos and occasionally running a 24-hour towing business.

**AARON WICKENDEN (associate producer)** began his professional career in the medium of still photography. He parlayed a job in Print Viewing at the Center for Creative Photography into internships with Richard Avedon and Annie Leibovitz. His interest in documentary film grew from internship with Peter Broderick's Next Wave Films where he helped to coordinate the grass roots publicity campaign for the award winning doc *Fighter*. After relocating to Chicago in 2002, Aaron became the Post Production Coordinator on Kartemquin Films' award winning series *The New Americans*. He is currently working as the assistant editor on Deborah Scranton's untitled documentary on soldiers in Iraq.

**GITA SAEDI (line producer)** is an award-winning independent documentary Producer/Director/Editor who has been working in film for over 15 years. She most recently served as the Series Producer for the PBS national series *The New Americans* - a 3-part, 7 hour series following five immigrant families journey to and first years in the U.S. Prior to *The New Americans*, she served on producing teams for Channel 4 in the UK, CBS and PBS in the U.S. and RTE in Ireland. Saedi currently lives in Montana with her husband where she is producing a multi-part series on Montana History for the state and pursuing new projects.

# Los Angeles Times

Sunday, July 21, 2002

FIRST PERSON

## Isle of Forgotten Fans

In Fiji, a decaying theater with patrons from 8 months to 80 rekindles an indie maven's love of film

By JOHN PIERSON

I recently became the proud owner of the world's most remote movie theater. A year from now, you could be wearing a T-shirt that says, "I saw it at the 180 Meridian Cinema." At least that's how I see it.

My wife and kids, whom I dearly love, have a slightly different take. They sing along gleefully to our new family theme song, "My Dad's Gone Crazy," thoughtfully provided by Eminem and his beloved daughter, Hailie, on the rapper's latest CD.

But gamely, they're leaving the very wired environs of New York later this week to join me in the bush and show movies at the edge of the world. Will our life be Swiss Family Robinson, without the treehouse, or "The Mosquito Coast, Part 2"? Tune in next year for the answer. Think "Osbournes Go Native," the difference being that if we launch a ham into the neighbor's yard, they will happily eat it.

The 180 Meridian Cinema is 5,000 nautical miles from the Santa Monica pier, mid-South Pacific, on one of Fiji's 323 islands. Theaters aren't normally built where dense rain forest meets pristine coral coast, especially on a volcanic island with no electricity, limited transportation on one unpaved road, and only a dozen small villages. In this primitive tropical paradise, waterfalls might outnumber people.



So much for demographics. On Taveuni, once a British colony, the villagers learn English in school, but they don't know from demographics. There's a full house, 288 sweaty bodies ranging in age from 8 months to 80, in every last 1954-vintage seat every night.

That's because, aside from church, the 180 Meridian Cinema is the only entertainment game in town. And with a little help from filmmakers like Kevin Smith and the "[Blair Witch](#)" gang whom I've helped along the way, the price of admission is the same as the nearby Catholic mission. The movies are always free.

We'll compete for those souls. Step right up. Walk right in under the iconic images of a welcoming Mickey and Bugs, painted above the front entrance years ago to greet would-be cineastes (Disney and Warner Bros., feel free to sue). Thanks to a diesel generator, see whatever film has been disgorged by the rust-bucket ferry this week. It could be "Harry Potter and the Sorcerer's Stone" or "Ghost Dog, the Way of the Samurai," "The Fast and the Furious" or "Memento." Here at the end of the global distribution food chain, all films are created equal.



There are no media. TV or radio ads would be useless on an island where TV and radio broadcasts are virtually unavailable. You couldn't buy a magazine if your life depended on it. It's all word of mouth or, in the local lingo, coconut wireless.

Event pictures like "Pearl Harbor" and "Spider-Man" arrive mercifully hype-free, to be judged solely on their own merits. Even the mighty "Star Wars" has no imperial advantage here. In fact, Taveuni may be the only safe haven on the globe where the Force is a dud.

Science fiction doesn't fit in the villagers' hardscrabble reality. "They know it's baloney," according to the former theater owner. On the other hand, no one liked "Cast Away" because it played like a (very long) documentary.

Preferences emerge over time. 007, in all actor incarnations, is a favorite. Jet Li and George Clooney (especially in "The Peacemaker") are coming on strong. But no one can hold a candle to the Third World's biggest action hero, Jean-Claude Van Damme. Ask any Taveuni man, woman or child. If the Muscles From Brussels ever visited the island, he'd go from straight-to-video to straight-to-the-throne, crowned as King of the Fijians. (Consider this an invitation.)

But only Curly is God. We discovered the local worship of the Three Stooges quite by accident on our first trip to the island two years ago. This tale really begins at the close of 1999. Being the guy Variety had long described as "the guru of independent film" wasn't fun anymore. I'd lost that sustaining sense of delight in the movies.

So combining midlife crisis with grand adventure, and seasoning with a pinch of disgust over Y2K hysteria, we started searching for a millennial destination with a movie tie-in. That way, the whole boondoggle could be charged off to "Split Screen," my cable TV show (now in repeats on IFC). Spurning Tonga and Kiribati, we targeted Fiji.

Somewhere out on the international dateline, we meant to show the first movie of the new millennium. Instead, after a two-month delay, we stumbled upon the world's most remote cinema. The 18-seat Chinese surplus prop plane that takes you to Taveuni's jungle airstrip is a time machine. It takes you to the future and past all at once: the future because it's always tomorrow on the magical dateline, and the past because it's always 1954, the year the 180 Meridian Cinema opened.

The agricultural economy (copra and kava) was better then. An average weekly wage now is \$20. Yet even the poorest ramshackle, tin-hut dwelling villager knows the cinema is a bit of a dump, moldy and unchanged in all that time. It exists because one man, Ambraham Dayaram, a proud Indian who is the Fitzcarraldo of Fiji, had a vision that juxtaposed two concepts: Let's build a memorial hall to honor Mahatma Gandhi, and let's show movies in the middle of the jungle. He's still kicking at 86, and if you ask him, like I did more than once, "Why'd you do it?," he'll give you a three-word answer: "Movies are good."

Just like Joel McCrea's director in "Sullivan's Travels," I had forgotten how good movies are. I was vividly reminded when Ambraham's son Dhansukh, who had run the joint for years, pulled out a Three Stooges short. Since its opening, through three generations of filmgoers, the 180 Meridian Cinema has regularly, nearly ritualistically, screened three Three Stooges two-reelers that were never returned to the film distributor. All three are venerated.

But "Some More of Samoa," their one and only South Pacific escapade in which Curly goes jaw to jaw with a crocodile, got the most ecstatic reaction I have ever witnessed in a lifetime spent at the movies. It was the pure bliss of maximum movie



pleasure. That's when I knew I would return.

One coup later, I made it back in the summer (their winter, although you wouldn't know it) of 2001. The tension had spiked between the indigenous Fijians and the ever-growing Indo-Fijian population (Indians were brought over by the British in the 1870s as indentured servants on sugar plantations, and they still can't own tribal lands). In fact, Dhansukh had decided to immigrate to New Zealand and the theater was likely to close.

Within 24 hours, before Cinema Paradiso could become the Last Picture Show, I decided I had to buy it. I immediately reached out to my most successful indie discoveries to assemble the money for a foundation and (half seriously) future Fiji film colony--without the Kool-Aid.

The first request went to the reputedly generous Michael Moore, riding high on "Stupid White Men" and "Bowling for Columbine" these days. (He is the "Mike" in my book "Spike, Mike, Slackers & Dykes.") His six-word response: "Ugh, tell me this isn't happening." Had I miscalculated? Not at all. The next four pitches raised a six-figure kitty. Kevin Smith, Spike Lee, "South Park's" Matt Stone, and the ["Blair Witch"](#) partners all supported the cause, calling it absolutely crazy--as they sent in their checks.

Now we'll see if they come. Kevin already balked, observing that "there's too much dirt in the jungle." If Milla Jovovich is out there, you're invited back to the scene of your first film, "Return to the Blue Lagoon." It's the only feature ever shot in Taveuni (1988), and they're still talking about you.

In the end, what's the fun of being an amateur anthropologist halfway around the world in a land with no trades, no grosses, no toy tie-ins, no Entertainment Weekly "Entertainment Tonight," if you can't convince your family to come along for the ride. Quite unexpectedly, and with no coercion aside from the promise of a pet pig, my wife, Janet, daughter, Georgia, 15, and son, Wyatt, 12 (future pig owner), agreed. Collectively they leave behind a year of private school, PlayStation 2, MP3s, Dunkin' Donuts, instant messaging, orthodontia, malls, "TRL," yoga, Abercrombie & Fitch--for swarms of mosquitoes.

Swiss Family Robinson meet Fiji Family Pierson. We won't be scaling ropes into a treehouse, but life in a solar-powered, 125-year-old wooden plantation house--where the mud wasps and termites work overtime, the geckos eat the bugs, and the house girl cleans the gecko dung--will have its challenges.

At least Fijian cannibals stopped eating their vanquished enemies in the 1860s. One of the largest naval battles between Tonga and Fiji, fought in outrigger canoes, took place directly offshore from where the 180 Meridian Cinema stands. A French priest advised the fierce Fijians on strategy. They prevailed, baked the Tongans, and built the beautiful Catholic mission church to thank him. Our one local eatery, the Cannibal Cafe, would still "love to have you for dinner."

I wasn't necessarily thinking of some of today's real dangers when I plotted my escape. But after Sept. 11, a lot of people took it that way. I guess I'm just as happy to be getting my family far away from the nuclear power plant that sits like an inviting target 10 miles from our house.

If you ever saw the 1950s nuclear holocaust scare movie "On the Beach," you know that due to its extreme remoteness and prevailing winds, Fiji's quadrant is the safest spot on the globe.

What's our Hollywood ending? It's way too soon to tell. However, in a cautionary aside to studio executives, I'm here to tell you that Fijians won't care. With each film I've played this year, 15% to 20% of the audience walks out in the last two minutes. Whether they've loved the picture, or merely found it tolerable, no matter how predictable it's been all along, they just don't feel a need to see how it ends.

So all the market research screenings, rewrites, re-shoots, re-edits and further test screenings that consume the Hollywood studios are of no use here. And it's certainly not because anyone needs to beat the traffic home.

Sota tale.

John Pierson wrote "Spike, Mike, Slackers & Dykes" and created IFC's "Split Screen" after a decade of representing and financing many first-time features.

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## **Production Credits**

*(Credits Not Contractual)*

Directed by  
Steve James

Produced By  
Steve James  
Scott Mosier

Executive Producers  
Kevin Smith  
John Pierson  
Janet Pierson

Co-Producer / Director of Photography  
P.H. O'Brien

Editor  
Steve James

Music Composer  
Norman Arnold

Associate Producer / Post Production Supervisor  
Aaron Wickenden

Line Producer  
Gita Saedi

For making this film possible, the filmmakers gratefully  
acknowledge

John Pierson  
Janet Pierson  
Georgia Pierson  
Wyatt Pierson  
180 Meridian Cinema  
The people of Taveuni

Location Sound  
Richard K. Pooler

Online Editor  
Cyndi Moran

Music Supervisor  
Linda Cohen

Accountant  
Chris Kahn

Additional Editing  
Aaron Wickenden

Stills Photographer  
Amy C. Elliott

Driver / Fixer  
Nand Lal

Translators  
Keni Madden  
Teresa Donovan

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Tuks Cakau  
Petero Gopal  
Teresia Gopal  
Waisake Rokotuitai  
Lavinia Taylor

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Celeste Neuhaus

Offline Editing Suite  
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Assistant Editor  
Aaron Wickenden

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Zak Piper  
Leslie Simmer

Online Editing  
Media Process Group, Chicago

Post Production Sound Services  
Skywalker Sound  
A Division of Lucas Digital Ltd.

Rerecording Mixers  
Juan Peralta  
Gary Rizzo

Legal Services  
Sloss Law Office

Phase One Instigators  
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Gregg Hale  
Mike Monello  
Dan Myrick  
Eduardo Sanchez  
Kevin Smith  
Matt Stone  
Don Ward  
Chris Zarpas

VINAKA

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Anna Bibi  
Elia Bibi  
Elisabeta Bibi  
Miriam Bibi  
Waga Bibi  
Narendra Chand

Salo Chana  
Bina Chand  
Sudesh Chand  
Subhash Chandra  
Babu Chawada  
Andrew Coghill  
Bruce Delai  
Alumeci Evans

Joseph Evans  
Lavinia Evans  
Sake Evans  
Sisilia Evans  
Tawake Evans  
Vilisita Evans  
Yale Evans  
Petero Gopal  
Teresia Gopal  
Father Lewis Henry  
Robert Leonard Koroi  
Father Kosi  
Chandra Kumari  
Nand Lal  
Jacqueline Low  
Father Ben McKenna  
Ramesh Mishra  
Eliza Nair  
Vijendra Nair  
Dan Negoianu  
Brother Simon O'Connor  
Gerard O'Brien  
Rob Park  
Chandrika Prasad

Dinesh Prasad  
Michael Prasad  
Pita Radio  
Vilimone Raqiawa  
Reme Ravia  
Waisake Rokotuitai  
Ronald Sami  
Mary Saumi  
Vilitati Savirio  
Anil Shankaran  
Atish Shankaran  
John Shankaran  
Nanise Aba Sharndil  
Marcia Tambalala  
Lavinia Taylor  
Patrick Taylor  
Tekae Tioruakavo  
Noa Tokavou  
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Berenadeta Veitoyaki  
Tino Vereti  
Fabiano Vovokyro  
Sam Wakehm

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Warren Dern  
James Dorgan

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Peer Ebbighausen  
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Eminem  
Dave England  
Devin Flynn  
Casandra Franceschi  
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David Gale  
Paul Garcia  
Jennifer Gaylord Rohrer  
Richard Gere  
Craig Giummarra  
Clive Graham  
Curtis Hanson  
Matt Harvey  
Bob Hercules  
Tommy Redmond Hicks  
Hugh Jackman

Janna Johnson  
Spike Jonze  
Christie Jordan  
Johnny Knoxville  
Sharmalee B. Lall  
Preston Lacy  
Tim Lanza  
Queen Latifah  
Spike Lee  
Claire Lincoln  
Ed Limato  
Roni Lubliner  
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Daniel Moore  
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Terese Olsen  
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Doug Pensak  
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Nicholas Patton  
Joe Rangel  
Andrea Scharf  
Jonathan Seliger  
Bob Weinstein  
Harvey Weinstein



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Suva Motor Inn  
The Village of Natokalau  
The Village of Wairiki

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Ming Chen

### **SONGS**

"Chookar Mere Man Ko"  
Written by Anjaan Rajesh Roshan  
Performed by The Garden Island Resort Band  
Courtesy of South Pacific Recordings, Ltd.

"Crazy Rap"  
Written by Joseph Foreman  
Performed by Miriama Bibi and Georgia Pierson

"Isa Noqu Dauloman"  
Written by Petero Logalaca  
Performed by The Garden Island Resort Band  
Courtesy of South Pacific Recordings, Ltd.

"Can You See Me"  
Written by Adam Green  
Performed by Adam Green  
Courtesy of Rough Trade / Sanctuary Records Group



"Ich Bein Ein Manipulator"

Written by Devin Flynn  
Performed by Devin Flynn  
Courtesy of Devin Flynn

"Roxie"

Written by Fred Ebb and John Kander  
Performed by Renée Zellweger  
Courtesy of Miramax Films

"We Both Reached For The Gun"

Written by Fred Ebb and John Kander  
Performed by Renée Zellweger and Richard Gere  
Courtesy of Miramax Films

"Shook Ones Pt. 2"

Written by Albert Johnson and Kejuan Muchita  
Performed by Mobb Deep  
Courtesy of the RCA Records Label

"Lunch Truck Rap"

Written by Marshall Mathers  
Performed by Marshall Mathers  
Courtesy of Universal Studios

"Everybody From the 313 Rap"

Written by Marshall Mathers  
Performed by Marshall Mathers  
Courtesy of Universal Studios

"Stop Dreamin'"

Written by Albert Spaulding, Casey Bridgeford and  
Sheronn Hooks  
Performed by DaFilled  
Courtesy of Adim Management

"Pate Pate"

Written by Opetaiia Foa'i and Malcolm Smith  
Performed by Te Vaka  
Courtesy of Warm Earth Records

"Isa Na Bula"

Written by Petero Logalaca  
Performed by The Garden Island Resort Band  
Courtesy of South Pacific Recordings, Ltd.

"Luvuci Au (A Love Song)"  
Written by Petero Logalaca  
Performed by The Garden Island Resort Band  
Courtesy of South Pacific Recordings, Ltd.

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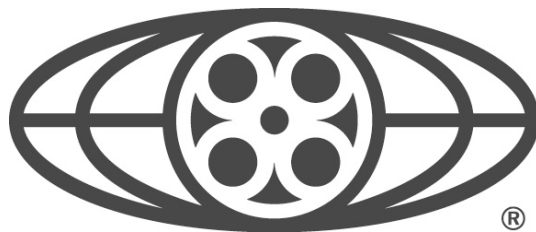
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